Modern ogee bowl

Andy Coates gives the traditional ogee shape a colourful twist

PHOTOGRAPHS BY ANDY COATES

When you turn five days a week it's easy to become bored with turning wood. Jobs that have to be done to pay the bills can become chores to be resented and put off, but that's rarely an option. So when you have some free time it's a form of respite just to turn for the sake of turning. If the result is something pleasing, and especially if somebody else thinks so and purchases it, it can do wonders for your mood and general enjoyment of your craft.

Quite often during these respite periods I return to 'old shapes'; forms and shapes that are beyond the claim of any individual because they are set in the deep history of the hand-made vessel. They're a safe bet, tried and tested and found to be good standards of a type. The ogee bowl is one such shape.

The ogee itself is a spindle turning shape, appropriated for the faceplate-age long ago, so spindle turning is a good grounding for learning the intricacies of the shape and its formation on the woodturning lathe. Incidentally, there's never a reason not to spindle turn. It's always a learning process, and always transferable to the faceplate – or 'scroll chuck' in modern parlance. So a 10-minute 'spindle session' before every allocated or stolen slot of workshop time is a good way to warm up the muscles and refresh the connection between eye and hands. It's never wasted time or timber.

The ogee shape works well on a bowl, and can bridge a gap between the purely utilitarian and the decorative. On occasion, however, it can look a little staid. It is, of course, all a matter of taste, but the ogee bowl can be given a contemporary edge.

I've made many ogee bowls over recent years; all different, but stemming from the same traditional shape. A tweak here and there to the shape, a different treatment, such as carving, texturing, colouring or even a combination of a number of these can all work wonders in lifting what might be a quite ordinary object into something a little more special. And it can also rehabilitate a drab piece of wood, or help to highlight the features of a particularly nice piece.

Over this time it has also occurred to me that creating interest in the objects we make – especially the more speculative ones – is all about tension. It's the tension created between features that draws the eye – and hopefully the wallet – from the pocket of a prospective purchaser. So, where might we create tension? And how?

The most obvious place is between the chosen material, wood, and something else. In this case modern paint finishes. Spray paint technology has progressed in leaps and bounds over recent years, evidenced by the introduction of artists' spray paints, which seem to be forging a path through art shops and online suppliers. These paints – if not their spray heads – have improved dramatically. Water-based sprays have emerged and a vast array of colours and finishes are available to try. If you don't fancy kitting yourself out with a dedicated airbrush system these paints can provide an inroad to a more refined finish when compared to brushed-on paints. So dig into your piggy bank, invest in some wild colours and give it a whirl. But for this project I'm eschewing the 'wild' and returning to an old favourite: red and black; although I did plump for a vivid and dramatic cadmium red. I'll also be adding something to add an aged effect to the paint. So, let's get on. I have used a piece of unidentified garden ornamental but you could use anything suitable. In fact, something fairly plain is ideal.

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Andy is on the Register of Professional Turners (RPT) and is Chairman of the AWGB. He is a professional woodturner and has a workshop and gallery in Suffolk. He mostly makes one-off pieces, but like any jobbing woodturner, is just as likely to be found doing small batch runs, antique restorations or any number of strange commissions. He also demonstrates and teaches turning.

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